

BEFORE

The great Egyptian civilization of the Old Kingdom with its godlike pharaohs had its origins in earlier dynasties.

PRE-DYNASTIC EGYPT

The period between early Neolithic settlement and c. 3100 BCE is known as the Pre-Dynastic Era. Egypt existed in two parts—the north

(Lower Egypt) and the south (Upper Egypt). Evidence discovered in tombs suggests a wealthy society, and that people believed in an afterlife.

EARLY DYNASTIC ERA

The Early Dynastic Era (c. 3100–2686 BCE) covers the 1st and 2nd dynasties. **Menes, or Horus Aha**

« 45, who united the kingdoms of Upper and Lower Egypt, is usually thought to be the first pharaoh. However, Narmer may have come first, or Narmer may be another name for Menes.

A SENSE OF IDENTITY

The Early Dynastic Era gave Egypt a strong sense of identity. It brought a sudden (as yet unexplained) rise to greatness, with more complex irrigation programs, grander royal tombs, a centralized state headed by a king with a semidivine identity, and a form of writing.

ARCHITECT AND PHYSICIAN

IMHOTEP

Imhotep is credited as the main architect of Djoser's "step pyramid." Djoser was the second pharaoh of the 3rd dynasty (c. 2686–2613 BCE) and Imhotep was his chief adviser and physician, as well as being the leading genius of his day. His step pyramid is seen as the building that helped establish the Old Kingdom as an era of remarkable achievement. The oldest surviving building made from cut blocks of stone, it was the first true Egyptian pyramid.

Giza's great tombs adapted Imhotep's design, but filled in the stepped sides to produce what we now think of as the classic pyramid. Imhotep's skills as a physician were such that he was worshipped as a god in later ancient Egypt and Greece.

IMHOTEP

The Divine Pharaohs

Egypt's Old Kingdom (c. 2686–2181 BCE) flourished on the flood-enriched banks of the Nile River. It was an era of prosperity, relative stability, and strong centralized rule, during which the great pyramids were built and Egyptian society worshipped their mighty kings, or pharaohs, as "gods on Earth."

Old Kingdom society was tightly controlled by a centralized government headed by a highly powerful ruler, the pharaoh. Central to life, politics, and religion, which were all closely combined, was the idea that the pharaoh was a semi-divine figure who acted as mediator between the gods and his subjects.

As a religious and political leader, the pharaoh not only oversaw elaborate religious rituals that underlined his links with the gods, he also headed a vast, highly organized political and administrative bureaucracy, peopled by an army of advisors and officials, chief of which was an officer called a vizier. The bureaucracy also included local governors, who oversaw regions called *nomes* (former independent regions). Pharaohs are often seen as being despotic. However, although their word was law, the pharaohs did delegate a significant amount to the governors and, as the Old Kingdom progressed (see AFTER), gave them more and more power.

Kingdom of the Sun

The first pharaohs were believed to be earthly representations of the mythical figure Horus, son of the god Osiris, and Isis (see pp.68–69). Horus was strongly linked with Ra (or Re), creator of life and falcon-headed god of the Sun. The Sun cult became very important during the Old Kingdom and Ra emerged as a separate figure from Horus. "Ra" even became incorporated into pharaohs' names.

Through these connections, the pharaoh was the upholder of a justice system that aimed to reflect the cosmic order. He was also, vitally, the figure who worked with the gods to ensure that the Nile brought silt-rich annual floods each year, keeping the Nile Valley fertile enough to support the great Egyptian state.

The pharaoh was the ultimate all-seeing, all-knowing figure. He was often depicted dressed in a kind of kilt and false beard, bearing a crook, flail, and scepter, and with the double crown of Lower and Upper Egypt on his head.

A cobra, the "eye" of Ra, was shown rising up off his forehead. He was accompanied by the royal fan-bearer, and people fell prostrate before him. Egyptians did seem to realize he was a flesh-and-blood human, but they stood in awe of his sacred power.

"Gift of the Nile"

Ancient Greek historian Herodotus described the Nile's bounty as a "gift." The mighty river cut a huge valley in the northeastern corner of Africa (see pp.64–65). To the north, in Lower Egypt, the Nile's tributaries fanned out to create a wide, fertile delta, home to a high concentration of people. At the delta's south was the "capital city" of Old Kingdom Egypt—Memphis. Farther south, in Upper Egypt, the valley

snaked away in a narrow strip, with towns clinging to its fertile banks.

The Nile's annual inundation left in its wake the rich black silt on which the Egyptians relied to grow their crops. Vast irrigation programs were



Population of builders

This relief of an Egyptian shipyard is from a 5th-dynasty (c. 2494–2345 BCE) official's tomb at Saqqara. Ships were vital for travel along the Nile and for trade with some of Egypt's neighbors.



devised to direct the waters to wide areas of agricultural land. Marshlands along the banks provided waterfowl for eating (by wealthy people only) and the papyrus reed, used for making writing materials. The river waters themselves supplied fish and a means of getting from one place to another. The Egyptians, surrounded by vast stretches of arid, inhospitable desert, were only too aware of how dependent they were on this massive floodplain. As a result, lookouts were posted along the Nile in southern Egypt to spot early signs of high or low waters that would affect the annual harvest.

Society's pecking order

Society was fairly clearly divided into different levels. At the top was the royal family, presiding over court and administrative officials, such as scribes, and also priests. There was a strict pecking order, and showing duty and loyalty were top priorities.



The pharaoh Khafre

Khafre, also known as Khafra, Chephren, or Khephren, was the fourth king of the 4th dynasty. This statue, showing him wearing a false beard and striped "nemes" headcloth, is from his pyramid-tomb complex at Giza.

